Seranai

OpenFOS

Open Founder Operating System

Persona Definition & Testing

24 Skills + 2 Reference Modules
Organized by FOUNDRY Framework

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Why Most B2B Personas Fail

Here's a hard truth: most buyer personas are useless. They sit in a Google Doc, describe a fictional person named "Marketing Mary" with a stock photo, list some demographics, and never get referenced again. They're a checkbox exercise, not an operating tool.

This happens because most persona frameworks were built for B2C consumer marketing, then awkwardly grafted onto B2B. In consumer markets, demographics matter: a 25-year-old urban professional shops differently than a 55-year-old suburban retiree. But in B2B, demographics are a sideshow. B2B International's 2024 research found that demographic criteria are relevant for only 15% of B2B purchasing decisions. What actually drives decisions: functional requirements (87%), strategic goals (72%), and process-related factors (64%).

The second failure mode is the "single buyer" myth. Most founders build one persona and write all their messaging for that one person. But Gartner's 2024 research shows the average B2B purchase involves 6-10 decision-makers, each arriving with 4-5 pieces of independent research. Forrester pushes the number even higher: 13 stakeholders, with 89% of purchases crossing multiple departments. You're not selling to a person. You're selling to a committee.

This skill fixes both problems. It builds personas grounded in Jobs-to-Be-Done (why they buy) and maps the full buying committee (who else needs to say yes). Every element is testable, and every test has a clear pass/fail signal.

The Three-Lens Persona Model

This skill fuses three complementary frameworks into a single persona. Each lens answers a different question:

Lens	Question It Answers	What It Informs
Demographics & Firmographics	Where do I find this buyer? What title, company size, industry?	LinkedIn targeting, outbound lists, conference selection, ad targeting
Jobs-to-Be-Done	Why do they buy? What outcome are they hiring a product to achieve?	Positioning, messaging, feature priorities, pricing justification
Buying Committee	Who else needs to say yes? What does each stakeholder care about?	Sales strategy, content variety, objection handling, deal acceleration

Lens 1: Demographics That Matter (and Those That Don't)

In B2B, only demographic attributes that causally affect the buying decision belong in the persona. Job title matters (it determines budget authority). Company size matters (it determines buying process complexity). Industry matters (it determines regulatory context and pain specifics). Age, gender, and personal hobbies almost never matter and can actually create harmful stereotypes that bias your sales team.

Lens 2: Jobs-to-Be-Done

Clayton Christensen's JTBD framework asks: "What job is the customer hiring this product to do?" The classic example: people don't buy a quarter-inch drill because they want a drill. They buy it because they want a quarter-inch hole. In B2B, the JTBD has three layers:

- Functional job: The practical task (automate reporting, reduce compliance risk, accelerate deployment)
- Emotional job: How they want to feel (confident, in control, relieved of stress, competent)
- Social job: How they want to be perceived (innovative, responsible, strategic, efficient)

Gartner's 2025 research shows JTBD-based marketing strategies lead to 34% higher conversion rates in B2B sales. The reason: when your messaging matches the buyer's actual job, they feel understood. When it matches only their demographics, they feel targeted.

Lens 3: The Buying Committee

Modern B2B purchases are committee decisions. The five roles you need to map:

1. Champion: The internal advocate who discovers your solution and sells it internally. This is your primary marketing target. They're mid-level (manager to director), feel the pain directly, and are willing to champion an unknown vendor.
2. Economic Buyer: Controls the budget. Cares about ROI, risk, and strategic alignment. Enters late, wants executive summaries, has high veto power.
3. Technical Validator: Evaluates security, integration, and architecture. Can block deals on technical grounds. Documentation-first evaluation style.
4. End User: Uses the product daily. Low formal veto power, but poor adoption kills renewals. The #1 churn driver in B2B SaaS.
5. Procurement/Legal: Manages contracts and compliance. Enters very late. Process-driven. Can delay but rarely kills deals the business wants.

Anatomy of a Complete Persona Card

The skill generates a full persona card with six blocks. Here's what each contains and why it matters:

1. Identity Block

Job title, company type and size, reporting structure, team size, experience range, and where they spend time online. This block answers: "Can I build a LinkedIn Sales Navigator filter that returns this person?" If you can't, the identity isn't specific enough.

2. Job-to-Be-Done Block

Primary JTBD statement in standard format, functional/emotional/social jobs, success metric, and failure metric. This block answers: "What language should my landing page headline use?" The JTBD statement should be usable as the seed for positioning and copy.

3. Day-in-the-Life Block

A 3- 4 sentence narrative describing a typical workday. What meetings dominate their calendar? What tools are on their screen? What stresses them at 4pm? This block creates empathy and prevents the persona from being an abstraction. It answers: “When is this person most receptive to my outreach?”

4. Pain & Trigger Block

Top 3 pains ranked by severity, primary and secondary trigger events, current workaround, and cost of status quo. This block answers: “What should my outbound email lead with?” and “When should I time my outreach?” Trigger events are the most actionable element, they tell you WHEN the buyer is in market.

5. Buying Behavior Block

Discovery channels, evaluation methods, deal killers, decision timeline, and budget authority. This block answers: “Where do I show up?” and “What will kill my deal?” The deal killer list is particularly valuable, it prevents the founder from wasting weeks on deals that will die at the technical validation or procurement stage.

6. Messaging Guidance

One LinkedIn-stopping sentence, one sales-opening question, one objection-proof point, words the persona uses, and words to avoid. This block is directly actionable, the founder can paste the LinkedIn sentence into their outreach template within minutes of receiving the persona.

The Anti-Persona: Your Most Underrated Tool

For every buyer you should pursue, there’s a lookalike you should avoid. The anti-persona defines the prospect who looks right on paper but will never convert. Defining this saves more time than defining the persona itself.

Common anti-persona patterns:

- The Tire-Kicker: Engages enthusiastically with demos but has no budget, no timeline, and no urgency. Signal: asks many questions, never involves colleagues.
- The Feature Blocker: Interested but has one non-negotiable technical requirement you can’t meet. Signal: asks about the missing feature in the first 2 minutes of every call.
- The Wrong Size: Company too small to afford your price or too large to accept your maturity. Signal: sticker shock or enterprise security requirements.
- The Satisfied Competitor User: Already using a rival and moderately happy. Switching costs exceed benefits. Signal: “We use X and it’s fine.”
- The Innovator Tourist: Loves the concept but works at an organization that won’t support the purchase. Signal: individual enthusiasm meets organizational inertia.

Persona Confidence: Know What You Know

Not all personas are created equal. A persona built from 15 customer interviews is fundamentally different from one built from founder intuition. The skill rates every persona on a 5-level confidence scale:

Level	Based On	Safe To Use For
5: Research-Validated	10+ structured conversations, validated JTBD, tested messaging	Product decisions, major marketing investments, hiring
4: Interview-Informed	3- 9 conversations, confirmed JTBD, partial committee mapping	First outbound campaigns, landing page copy, sales playbook v1
3: Evidence-Supporte d	Market research + 1–2 conversations, competitor analysis	Hypothesis testing, initial outreach experiments
2: Hypothesis-Stage	Analogies and market signals, founder experience	Discovery conversation guides, initial targeting
1: Assumption-Based	Founder intuition, no direct buyer input	Nothing. Validate first.

The confidence level determines what decisions you can safely make. A Level 2 persona is fine for writing your first LinkedIn outreach. It is NOT fine for deciding what features to build next quarter. The 2-week validation sprint is designed to move your persona from Level 1-2 to Level 3–4.

The Data Behind the Framework

1. Demographics drive only 15% of B2B purchasing decisions (B2B International, 2024). Functional requirements drive 87%. This is why JTBD must be the core of every B2B persona.
2. Average B2B buying group includes 6-10 decision-makers (Gartner, 2024), each entering with 4- 5 pieces of independent research. Single-buyer personas miss the committee.
3. 89% of B2B buying decisions cross multiple departments (Forrester, 2024). Your persona strategy must address multiple stakeholders.
4. JTBD-based marketing achieves 34% higher conversion rates in B2B (Gartner, 2025). Motivation-based targeting outperforms demographic targeting.
5. 54.5% misalignment exists between how sellers and buyers define the problem (Emblaze, 2024). When alignment improves, win rates increase by 38%.
6. More than half of lost B2B deals are lost to “no decision” - not competitors. The committee fails to align. The buying committee map prevents this.
7. Buyers spend only 17% of purchase time with vendors (Gartner). Your persona must account for how the buyer behaves when you’re not in the room.

8. 41% of B2B buyers already have a preferred vendor before formal evaluation begins (Forrester, 2024). Persona-driven content strategy is how you become the pre-preferred vendor.

The Counter-Narrative

- Personas are models, not reality. Every individual deviates. The persona captures the 80% pattern; the salesperson handles the 20%.
- In product-led growth (PLG), the traditional committee may not apply at initial adoption. The end user becomes the champion, and the economic buyer enters only at expansion.
- AI is changing buyer behavior. Buyers use AI to research vendors, compare solutions, and draft RFPs. Personas built in 2026 should account for AI-augmented behavior.
- Emerging market buyers may have fundamentally different committee structures and relationship expectations. US/EU buying patterns don't always apply globally.
- Some successful B2B companies (notably Intercom) abandoned traditional personas entirely in favor of pure JTBD segmentation. The counter-counterargument: they still need to know WHERE to find these buyers, which requires demographic targeting.

How to Use This Skill

Describe your product, your beachhead market, or your best guess at who your buyer is. The skill will:

1. Instantly generate a buyer hypothesis with the three-buyer framework (champion, economic buyer, end user) and a JTBD quick-map
2. Ask 4- 6 sharpening questions about buying dynamics, triggers, and committee structure
3. Build a complete persona card with all six blocks, a buying committee map, an anti-persona, and a confidence score
4. Generate 10 falsifiable hypotheses covering identity, motivation, and behavior
5. Deliver a 2-week validation sprint with an interview guide, pattern recognition framework, and confirmation/pivot signals
6. Produce actionable outputs: outbound messaging templates, discovery call guides, and objection handling scripts

To get started, say: "Help me define the buyer persona for [your beachhead or product]."

The FOUNDRY Framework

FOUNDRY is the sequential journey framework that guides founders from initial idea through scale or exit. Each letter represents a stage, and each stage contains specific skills a founder needs to master.

Stage	Purpose	Skills
F – Foundation	Validate the idea. Confirm the problem is real, the market exists, and you know who to serve.	Skills 1–4
O – Outline	Design the business. Articulate value, map competition, model revenue, scope the MVP.	Skills 5–8
U – User	Acquire and understand customers. Discover needs, design GTM, set pricing, run experiments.	Skills 9–12
N – Nurture	Build relationships and traction. Craft the pitch, model financials, build the founder narrative.	Skills 13–15
D – Discipline	Execute and operate. Set OKRs, hire the team, handle legal and entity setup.	Skills 16–18
R – Results	Measure and iterate. Track KPIs, assess PMF, decide whether to pivot or persevere.	Skills 19–20
Y – Yield	Scale or exit. Confirm scaling readiness, plan liquidity events.	Skills 21–22

Cross-cutting skills (23- 24) are not stage-specific and can be invoked at any point in the journey.

Reference modules (R1- R2) are shared evaluation lenses that multiple skills invoke. They are never used in isolation.

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